the public. Apart from validating the presidential decrees on the States of Emergency in Rakhine State and Meiktila, the Hluttaw's involvement was minimal, for three reasons: (i) the Hluttaw was slow to respond to the fast-moving nature of communal conflict compared to the executive, and its options were limited to consultations, oversight of the government, and law-making; (ii) it was an extremely sensitive issue and legislators did not want to be branded either as ultra-nationalists or Muslim sympathizers; and (iii) while it has tried its best to accommodate ethnic conflicts, the legislature was unprepared for this type of communal conflict based on religious lines. Only three Muslims sat in the Hluttaw. There are ad hoc committees for ethnic groups affairs, but not on religious minorities such as Christians and Muslims, which make up about eleven per cent of the total population (CSO 2012).

Though its involvement was weak, the Hluttaw was effective in preventing itself from becoming a source of conflict. After the Rakhine conflict, the legislature dealt with nine non-binding questions and five binding motions on communal violence.[12] Seven of these questions came from Rakhine Nationalities Development Party legislators and they were based on Rakhine resentment of Muslims. At the same time, none of the Muslim legislators raised any questions or motions in the legislature. Moreover, in the Rakhine State Hluttaw, four Muslims from Buthidaung and Maungdaw took long leave and quietly disappeared.[13] Next, the Hluttaw considered five motions on communal violence. Three were rejected citing their sensitivity and their potential to trigger more violence. One of the USDP motions was opposed by its own members.[14] Two were noted as requiring no action from the executive. According to an interview with an anonymous legislator, some of the motions were too sensitive and were rejected outright by the speakers. The legislature was careful not to escalate tension. A military legislator reflected on the atmosphere inside the legislature:

> The Hluttaw seemed quiet on communal conflict in Rakhine State. But it wasn't. Though we may have been silent in plenary sessions, there were a lot of informal discussions among us. Muslim legislators felt that everyone was against them. At the same time, Rakhine legislators felt that their questions and motions were rejected intentionally by the speakers. In reality, the speakers were conducting debates carefully so as not to become a source of conflict. And no one wanted to touch these issues publicly.[15]